

Raising Five Sons

*What It Costs to Be There, and the Father I Had to
Become*

James Bell

LIVEWELL BY JAMES BELL

*A father of the fatherless and a protector of widows is
God in his holy habitation.*

— Psalm 68, verse 5

Introduction: The Room I Had Never Seen

The night my first son was born, my wife handed him to me, and the room went quiet, and the first clear thought I had was that I did not know what I was doing.

I want to tell you where that came from, because it explains the whole book. I came to faith out of atheism as a grown man, and I was raised without a father, and those two facts are closer together than they look. I arrived in that delivery room with no working picture of the thing I was about to spend the rest of my life doing. I had never watched a father, up close and over years, do the ordinary work of fathering a son. I had seen the absence of it. I had assembled some idea of it out of films and older boys and the men I half watched from a distance. But I had not seen it, and now there was a person in my arms who needed me to be it, and I knew in my body, before I had any words for it, that I would have to build the whole thing from scratch and that I would fail at it more than I would succeed.

That happened five times. Five sons, over the better part of two decades, and I am still in the middle of it, and I am writing this not as a man who figured fathering out but as a man who was changed by it, slowly, in the failing, in the staying, in the ten thousand unremarkable days that no one will ever see. This is a book about those days. It is a book about what it actually costs to be there, every day, for boys who are watching you more closely than you will ever know, and about the strange thing that happened to me along the way, which is that in learning to be a

father I finally met the Father, the one in the Trinity, the one I had never had and had stopped believing existed.

I need to say at the start what this book is not. It is not a manual. I am suspicious of parenting manuals, and most of all of the ones written by men who make fathering sound like a system you can run correctly if you just have the right information. Fathering is not a system. It is a forming, and the one being formed is not only the son. It is the father. The man I was the night my first son was born could not have been the father those boys needed, because he was too young and too unfinished and too false, and the only thing that made him into something closer to what they needed was the long work of fathering them, which broke him open and put him back together more times than he can count.

So I am not going to give you steps. I am going to tell you the truth about being there, and about the vacancy that fathering exposed in me, and about the God I kept running into in the room where my sons were. I have come to believe that the most important thing a father does is also the thing our culture counts for nothing, and that almost everything we are told to chase as fathers is the wrong thing, and that the boys in the next room are being formed by what we are far more than by what we provide. I learned that the hard way, five times. Let me show you what they taught me.

Chapter One: The Vacancy

You do not know what you have lost, growing up without a father, until you are well into your thirties, and some men never know it at all. The loss does not announce itself. It is not the absence of a particular man you remember and miss. It is the absence of a whole category, the category that was supposed to tell you what a man does, what a man holds, what a man carries without flinching, and a boy without a father has to invent all of that, usually badly, out of whatever scraps the world hands him.

I invented mine out of movies. I invented them out of the older boys at the apartment complex who seemed to know things I did not. I invented them out of books, in the same library where, years later, I found the other books that would end my atheism. The inventing was always incomplete, and I carried into adulthood a particular vacancy, a shape cut out of me that nothing in my twenties could fill, and most of what I tried to fill it with left the hole worse than it found it. I am not going to overstate this. There are fatherless men who have grown into magnificent fathers, and there are men with present fathers who never recovered from them. But there is a specific emptiness the father-absent boy carries, and I have come to think the church has mostly been interested in it only as a problem to be solved with a program, when it is older and deeper than any program could reach.

It is so old that the Bible keeps returning to it. The God of Israel is named, again and again, as a Father to the fatherless, a defender of the widow, and most of the people those words were first written for would have heard them and wept, because they

knew the vacancy from the inside. We have domesticated those verses into greeting-card sentiment. They were not sentiment. They were a word spoken directly into the emptiest place a human being can carry, the place I carried, the promise that the category I had been forced to invent badly was real after all, and filled, and held by Someone who would not leave.

The loss is not the absence of a man you remember. It is the absence of the whole category that man was supposed to fill, and the boy without a father has to invent it, badly, from scratch.

I tell you this so you will understand that I did not come to fathering from a position of strength. I came to it from the vacancy. And here is the thing I could not have predicted. The vacancy did not disqualify me. It turned out to be the very place the work would happen, because a man who knows the shape of what he did not have is a man who knows, with terrible precision, what his sons must not be made to carry. I could not give my boys a model I had never seen. But I could refuse to pass on the absence. I could be there. And it turned out that being there, simply staying in the room I had never seen anyone stay in, was most of the thing I had spent my whole life believing I was incapable of.

Chapter Two: Formation Over Performance

We have taught fathers to measure the wrong thing, and the wrong thing is performance.

Ask a man what it means to be a good father and listen to how fast he reaches for the language of provision and achievement. He provides. He is present at the games. He pays for the things, secures the future, shows up at the recital, gets the promotion that buys the house in the district with the good schools. None of that is bad. Most of it is genuinely good, and a father who does none of it has abandoned his post. But notice that all of it is performance, all of it is doing, all of it is the kind of thing that can be photographed and counted and posted, and notice that a man can do every bit of it and still be forming his sons into something hollow, because the boys are not finally formed by what their father performs. They are formed by what their father is.

This is the distinction the whole book turns on, so let me be plain about it. There is the work you do for your family, and there is the work you let your family see you carry, and the second one is the one that forms them. Your son is not, in the deep places, being shaped by the money you make or the trophies he wins. He is being shaped by how you treat his mother when you are tired, by whether you tell the truth when the truth costs you, by what you do with your anger and your failure and your fear, by the man he watches you be on the unremarkable Tuesday when nothing is being photographed. That is formation, and formation

is slow and daily and almost entirely invisible, which is exactly why a performance culture cannot see it and does not value it and trains fathers to neglect it in favor of things that show.

The boys are not formed by what their father performs. They are formed by what their father is, on the Tuesday when no one is watching and nothing is being counted.

I gave too many years to performance before I understood this. I was a pastor, which is a profession that will happily consume every hour you have and call it faithfulness, and I told myself that providing for my sons and building something for them was the same as fathering them, and it was not, and the gap between those two things is where a lot of pastors lose their children. The boys did not need my performance. They needed my presence, and presence cannot be delegated or scheduled or bought, it can only be given, in person, over years, in the slow accumulation of ordinary days. Formation over performance. If you remember one thing from this book, remember that, because everything else I have to say is only an unfolding of it.

Chapter Three: Being There

My first son taught me that fathering is not first about doing. It is about being there, and the being there has to come before you have any idea what you are doing, or it will never come at all.

I have already told you that I held him in the delivery room convinced I was unqualified, and I was right, I was unqualified, in the sense that I did not possess the knowledge I assumed a father was supposed to have. What I did not understand yet was that he did not need me to possess that knowledge. He needed me to stay in the room while I did not possess it. He needed the presence more than the competence, and the presence was the one thing I could actually give, because it required nothing of me but to keep showing up, which a man can do even when he is failing at everything else. I did not know how to be a father. I knew how to be there. It turned out that being there, sustained over years, slowly becomes most of what being a father even is.

This is the part our anxious age cannot believe, because we have been trained to think that love is a performance and that if we do not have the right technique we will damage the child. So fathers stay away from the very places they are most needed, the hard conversation, the grief, the mess, because they do not know what to do there and they would rather be absent than be wrong. And the staying away does the damage the wrongness never would have. A father who is present and imperfect forms a son far better than a father who is competent and absent, because the son is not grading the technique, he is asking one question underneath everything, the question every child asks, which is, are you going to stay.

He did not need me to know what I was doing. He needed me to keep being there while I did not. The staying is most of the fathering.

I learned later that this is exactly how God fathers. He does not hand Israel a set of instructions and step back to see how they manage. He stays. The whole story is a story of a God who will not leave, who goes down into Egypt with them and out through the sea and around the wilderness for forty years of complaining, who is there, relentlessly there, when by every reasonable standard he should have walked away. The presence is the fathering. I read those passages differently now than I did before my first son, because I have stood in the room not knowing what I was doing, and stayed, and watched a boy grow up secure not because his father was capable but because his father was there. That is the thing I most wanted to give and was most afraid I could not. I could. It only ever required staying.

Chapter Four: The Weight a Father Carries

My second son taught me about weight, and specifically about the difference between the weight you carry for your family and the weight you let your family watch you carry, because it is the second one that forms a man.

There was a season of real conflict in the church I pastored, the kind that follows you home and sits at your dinner table whether you invite it or not. I tried, the way fathers do, to keep it from the boys, to hold my composure, to carry it where they could not see. And I mostly failed at the hiding, which turned out to be the best thing that could have happened, because my second son was watching. He was nine. I did not know he was watching. He told me, eight years later, that he had watched the way I held myself during that season, the way I kept getting up and going back into a situation that was costing me, the way I did not become cruel at home even though I had every excuse, and that it had taught him what a man does with weight. I had thought I was hiding it from him. I was actually teaching him with it.

This is one of the hardest and most freeing things I know about fathering. Your sons need to see you carry weight. Not be crushed by it, and not pretend it does not exist, but carry it, with your composure mostly intact and your tenderness mostly intact, back into the hard place one more time. A boy who never sees his father carry anything heavy does not learn how. He grows up thinking that the absence of weight is the goal, that a good life is a light one, and then the first real weight of his own adulthood

arrives and he has no idea what to do with it because he never watched it done. The father who lets his sons see him carry weight well is handing them the one skill no manual can teach, the skill of staying upright under a load.

There is the work you do for your family, and the work you let your family see you carry. The second one is the formative one. He was nine, and watching, and I did not know.

I came to understand that this is what the Father does, and what the Son saw. The whole drama of redemption is a weight no one else could carry, carried, in plain sight, by a Father whose Son was watching, and who himself went toward the cross. The Son becomes the man who can bear the unbearable thing because he saw it borne first. I do not want to make my small pastoral troubles into anything like that. But the pattern runs all the way down. Sons become the kind of men they watched their fathers be under load, and a father gets to decide, mostly, what they will see. Carry it where they can see you. Carry it well. They are learning their own future strength from your present one.

Chapter Five: Repent Quickly

My third son taught me to repent, and he taught me at the age of three, which is the age at which children are most honest and least able to be fooled by the performance of an adult.

He had been disobeying, genuinely, in the way three-year-olds do, and I was angry, and I raised my voice, and partway through it I caught sight of myself and understood that I was not actually angry about his disobedience. I was angry about the rest of the week. He was a small available target for a load that had nothing to do with him, and he was standing there, three years old, absorbing the overflow of a grown man's bad week as if it were about him, as if he had caused it, as if he were the problem. And I stopped. I sat down on the floor so I was beneath him, and I told him I was sorry, and I meant it completely, and he forgave me before I had even finished the sentence, the way only a small child can, with no interest in making me pay for it first.

That floor is one of the most important places I have ever been as a father. Because what I taught him in that moment was not that fathers are perfect, which is a lie that eventually curdles into either his contempt or his despair, but that fathers repent, that a man can be wrong and say so quickly and without defending himself, and that being wrong is survivable and need not be hidden. I have come to believe that a son is watching how his father handles being wrong far more closely than how he handles being right, because being right costs nothing, and the boy is trying to learn, from somewhere, how a man absorbs his own failure without either denying it or being destroyed by it. If he does not learn it from you he will learn it from no one, because

you are the first man he watches fail.

A son is watching how his father handles being wrong far more than how he handles being right. He will become the kind of man he sees you become on the floor.

And here, too, my son corrected my picture of God. I had inherited, from atheist parents and from the ambient religious noise of the culture, a picture of God as essentially angry, a Father lashing out from the rest of his cosmic week, displeased and ready to be set off. My three-year-old taught me, on that floor, that this was not fathering at all, it was just a tired man taking it out on a child, and that the real Father in the Trinity does not discipline us out of his own exhaustion but out of love and toward our forming. God's discipline is never the overflow of a bad week. It is always for us, always aimed at our becoming, never the random venting of a frustration we happened to be standing near. I did not know that in my body until I had to climb down onto the floor and learn it from a boy who forgave me before I finished asking.

Chapter Six: Delight

My fourth son taught me about delight, and I needed the lesson more than any of the others, because delight was the thing my picture of God most lacked.

He is the son whose temperament makes him almost impossible not to enjoy. He has been delighted with the world since he was an infant. He laughed about everything, and he still laughs, and being around him is like standing near a window that someone left open on a good morning. And watching him, over years, did something to me that no argument ever could have. It forced me to revise my idea of God, because I would catch myself lighting up when he walked into a room, delighting in him for no reason except that he existed and was mine, and then I would have to ask whether God might possibly feel that way about me, and everything in my inherited theology said no, and everything in my actual experience as a father said yes.

We have a hard time believing that God delights in us. We can believe he tolerates us, on a good day, for Christ's sake, holding his nose at our sin and letting us in on a technicality. We can believe he corrects us, certainly, we are very ready to believe that. What we cannot believe is that he looks at us and lights up, that his face does the thing my face did when my fourth son came into the room, that he actually enjoys us. And yet the Scripture says it plainly, in Zephaniah, that God rejoices over his people with gladness and exults over them with loud singing, and in Isaiah that he delights in them the way a bridegroom delights in his bride. I read those words for years as poetry I did not have to believe. My son made me believe them, because I

had felt the thing they describe, every morning, walking into the room of a boy whose face lit up at the sight of his ordinary, failing father.

A God who merely tolerates us, we can believe. What we cannot believe is that he looks at us and lights up. My son's face every morning made me believe it.

This is not a small correction. A great deal of joyless Christianity, and a great deal of joyless fathering, comes from a picture of God as fundamentally reluctant, a Father who is present out of obligation and whose approval must be continually earned and re-earned and is always one failure from being withdrawn. A boy raised by a father like that becomes a man who cannot rest, who is always performing for an approval that never quite arrives. But a boy raised by a father who delights in him, simply and obviously delights in him, before he has performed anything, learns in his bones that he is wanted, and that knowledge becomes the floor he stands on for the rest of his life. My fourth son taught me to give that floor to all of them. He also taught me that I had been standing on it the whole time without knowing it, held up by a Father whose delight in me did not wait for me to deserve it.

Chapter Seven: The Long Wait

My fifth son taught me about waiting, because he came later than the others, after a long stretch in which we thought he would not come at all.

There is a particular kind of forming that only happens in the waiting, and it does not happen in the easier seasons, and you cannot manufacture it or hurry it. The waiting for him was hard, harder than I will put on this page, and it did something in my wife and me that the quicker arrivals of the others had not done. And when he finally came, we knew exactly what we were holding, with a clarity the earlier joy had not had, precisely because we had spent so long not holding him, learning the shape of his absence, wanting him without any guarantee that the wanting would be answered. The waiting was not wasted. The waiting was part of how we came to love him. By the time he arrived we had been fathering him, in a way, through the whole long ache of his not yet being there.

I did not understand, as a younger man, that waiting could be a form of love rather than an interruption of it. I thought love was the having, and waiting was just the unpleasant corridor you passed through to get to the having. The fifth son corrected me. The waiting was love. The long stretch of wanting him and not having him was not empty time, it was the time in which a particular and unrepeatable love was formed, a love that could only exist on the far side of the wait, and would not have been the same love if it had come easily. Some of the deepest things a father feels are only available to him because he had to wait for them, and a man who has never had to wait for a child does not

know certain things about love that the waiting alone can teach.

I thought love was the having, and waiting was the corridor you passed through to reach it. The fifth son taught me the waiting was the love.

This rearranged how I read the patience of God. I had always heard the long waiting of God, the centuries between the promise and its keeping, the slow grind of redemptive history, as a kind of divine delay, a regrettable gap between what God intended and what God got around to. I hear it differently now. The waiting is part of the fathering. The God who has waited longer than any of us can imagine, who is patient toward us, who does not count slowness the way we count it, is not delayed. He is loving us in the wait, forming in the long ache a thing that could be formed no other way. My fifth son cost us a long wait, and the love on the other side of it was unlike any other, and I think that is the smallest possible glimpse of how God has been loving all of us, in the wait, the whole time we thought he was simply late.

Chapter Eight: The Father Wound and the Father

I have to stop and speak directly to the men who are reading this with the vacancy I described, because you are not incidental to this book, you are close to the center of it.

If you grew up without a father, or with one whose presence was its own kind of absence, you are carrying a wound that the culture either ignores or monetizes, and you have probably been told, in a hundred indirect ways, that you should be over it by now. You are not over it, and you will not get over it, and I want to tell you that this is not a failure of yours. The wound is real because the thing you lost was real. The category really was supposed to be filled, and it was not, and the part of you that aches is not being dramatic, it is telling the truth about a genuine absence. I will not insult you with the cheap version of this, the one that says God will simply fill the gap and you will feel whole and the ache will vanish. That is not how it has gone for me. The ache has not vanished. What has happened is stranger and better than its vanishing.

What has happened is that the very wound became the place I came to know the Father most truly, because a man who has never lacked a father has a harder time understanding why the Bible makes such an enormous deal of God being one. To a man who had a good father, the fatherhood of God is a pleasant addition, a nice way of putting it. To a man who had the vacancy, the fatherhood of God is not a metaphor, it is rescue, it is the filling of the exact hole he has carried his whole life, it is the

most important sentence in the universe. The fatherless are not at a disadvantage in knowing God as Father. We may, in the strange economy of grace, be at an advantage, because we know what the word costs and what it answers, and we cannot hear it as sentiment because we heard the silence where it should have been.

I will not tell you the wound vanishes. It has not for me. I will tell you the wound became the place I met the Father most truly, because I knew what the word cost.

So I became a father out of the vacancy, and I learned to father out of the vacancy, and I met the Father in the vacancy, and I have come to think that none of us, not the fatherless and not the well-fathered, has actually had the Father the doctrine describes. He is the Father none of us had, in his fullness, and the Father we are all being made by, and the Father every earthly father is at best a cracked and partial icon of. The best fathering I have ever done was only ever a rumor of his. And the worst news of my childhood, the missing man, turned out to be the doorway through which I walked to find the One who was never going to leave. I would not have chosen the vacancy. But I will not pretend it did not lead me home.

Chapter Nine: Teaching Them to Carry Weight

If the formation of a son is the father's real work, then somewhere in the middle of it comes the particular task of forming a boy into a man, and our moment has made a mess of this, and I want to say a careful word about it.

A young man today is handed two bad options and told to choose between them. He can take the path that says masculinity is essentially domination, that to be a man is to take and to win and to bend the world and the people in it to his will, and that strength is for the strong man's own use. Or he can take the path that says masculinity is essentially the problem, that the manly things in him are toxic by definition and the most virtuous thing he can do is apologize for them and shrink. Both of these are lies, and both of them produce broken men, the first a man who uses his strength against the weak and the second a man who has no strength to use at all, and a father who hands his son either of them has failed him.

There is a third thing, older than both, and it is the thing I have tried, badly and incompletely, to form in my sons. It is strength under control. It is the man who is genuinely strong, who has real weight and real force in him, and who has bound that strength entirely to the service and protection of the people who cannot protect themselves. It is power on a leash held by love. The Bible does not ask men to become weak, and it does not flatter the strong, it asks for strength governed, the lion who lies down, the warrior who washes feet, the King who is a Lamb.

That is the masculinity I want my sons to carry, and the only way to form it in them is to let them watch me try to carry it myself, because a boy does not learn manhood from a lecture about manhood, he learns it from watching a man.

A son does not learn manhood from a lecture about it. He learns it from watching a man carry strength on a leash held by love.

This is why the formation cannot be outsourced. We would love to outsource it, to a program, a coach, a curriculum, a youth ministry, and all of those can help, but none of them can do the central thing, because the central thing is a boy watching, day after day, how his own father uses the strength he has. Is the father's strength for himself or for others. Does he raise his voice at the weak or lower it. Does he keep his word when keeping it costs him. The son is taking all of it in, building his own future manhood out of the man in front of him, and there is no substitute, none, for that man being there and being worth watching. I am not always worth watching. But I am there, and I am trying, in front of them, to carry my strength the way the Lamb carried his, and that trying, witnessed daily, is the truest thing I can give them about what a man is.

Chapter Ten: The Table and the Catechism

A father is not only forming his sons by accident, by what they happen to catch him being. He is also meant to form them on purpose, and the place that happens, in my house and in the oldest practice of the faith, is the table.

I am not talking about anything elaborate. I am talking about the daily fact of a family that eats together and, at the table, does the unhurried work of handing the faith from one generation to the next, the reading, the questions, the prayers, the catechism, the slow rhythm by which a child comes to know not just what his family does but why, and not just the rules of the house but the God the house belongs to. We have largely lost this, and we have lost it to the very performance culture I named earlier, because the table is the first thing sacrificed when the family's life becomes a schedule of activities, each child shuttled to his own optimizing pursuit until there is no hour left when all of them are in the same room with nothing to do but be a family before God. The calendar is full and the table is empty, and we wonder why the faith does not pass down.

The old word for what happens at the table is catechism, and I have catechized my sons there, asking the ancient questions and teaching them the ancient answers, and I will tell you what happens when a boy actually hears them. He gets quiet. Because the culture has told him a thousand things about what to want and what to be and not one word about why he exists, and when you tell a boy at the table that he was made to glorify God and to

enjoy him forever, something settles in him that all the activities never settled. The table is where the why gets handed down. It cannot be handed down on the way to practice. It needs the unhurried hour, the faces around the food, the father who has decided that this, and not the next achievement, is the thing his sons most need from him.

The calendar is full and the table is empty, and then we wonder why the faith did not pass down. It was supposed to pass down at the table, and we gave the table away.

I have failed at this as much as I have succeeded, and the failures were almost always the same failure, letting the urgent crowd out the table, letting the performance win again over the formation. But the seasons when we kept the table, when we sat and read and prayed and asked the old questions, are the seasons my sons themselves remember as the spine of their childhood faith, and not one of them has ever told me he remembers an activity that way. The table is where a father does on purpose what he is doing by accident everywhere else, the handing down of a whole world. Keep the table. Of all the practical things I could tell a father, that is the one I would underline. Whatever else falls off the calendar, keep the table, because the table is where you get to be, on purpose, the father God is.

Chapter Eleven: Letting Go

There is a turn in fathering that no one prepares you for, and it is the hardest one, and it is the whole point, and it is this. The work of fathering a son is, from the beginning, the work of making yourself unnecessary.

This runs against every instinct. You spend years becoming the center of a small boy's world, the one he runs to, the one whose presence settles him, and then the entire aim of all that closeness turns out to be that one day he will not need it, that he will walk out of your house and into his own life and his own faith and his own fathering, and that your success will be measured precisely by how little he requires you anymore. A father who cannot let go has misunderstood the assignment from the start. The grip that was right when they were small becomes the thing that deforms them if it does not loosen, and the loosening is not the failure of the bond, it is its fulfillment, the bow finally releasing the arrow it was bent the whole time to send.

I have started to do this letting go, with the older ones, and I will tell you it costs more than I expected, because the same presence that was the gift now has to become, slowly, a stepping back, and the stepping back has to be done as deliberately and lovingly as the showing up ever was. It is its own kind of being there, this learning to be there less, to answer fewer of the questions, to let them carry weight I could still carry for them, to watch them fail at things I could still do for them, because the failing is now part of their forming and my rescuing would only rob them of it. The hardest fathering I have done is not the staying. It is the beginning of the leaving, the opening of the hand that spent

twenty years learning to hold.

The work of fathering a son is, from the first day, the work of making yourself unnecessary. The opening hand is not the failure of the bond. It is its fulfillment.

And of course this, too, is how the Father loves. The most famous father in all of Scripture is the one in the parable who lets his son go, who does not chain him to the estate or chase him down the road to drag him back, who endures the unbearable thing of watching a beloved son walk away into ruin because love that cannot be refused is not love at all. And then, when the son comes to himself and turns home, that same father is watching the road, and runs, an old man running, undignified with joy, to meet him while he is still a long way off. That is the shape of it. The letting go and the watching the road are the same love, and a father has to learn both, the open hand that releases and the watching eye that never stops hoping, and I am only beginning to learn them, and they are the truest and the costliest things fathering has asked of me yet.

Chapter Twelve: Still Being Fathered

I did not know God was a Father until I became one, and I am still finding out, and that is where this book has to end, because that is where I actually am.

Every son has been a chapter in a catechism I did not know I was being taught. The first taught me that being there is most of it. The second taught me to carry weight where they can see. The third taught me to repent quickly and to stop confusing my bad week with their discipline. The fourth taught me that God delights, actually delights, and the fifth taught me that the waiting is part of the love. And underneath all five of them, the whole time, I was being fathered myself by the One the boys kept pointing me back to, the Father I never had, the Father none of us has had in his fullness, the Father I have spent two decades slowly becoming and being made by at the same time. I came to him through philosophy and through a long library season and through the wreckage of my atheism. But the place I now meet him most reliably is not any of those. It is the room where my sons are.

I will not finish this catechism. I am not done being fathered, and they are not done being mine, and there is no version of this story in which I arrive at the end of it and present you with the completed man. The man is not completed. The fathering is still forming him, breaking him open and putting him back together, exposing the vacancy and filling it, on the ordinary unphotographed days that are the only days fathering ever actually happens on. I am a better man at the writing of this than I was the night my first son was handed to me in that quiet room,

and the difference is not anything I achieved. The difference is the boys in the next room, and the Father who used them to finish what my own missing father could not begin.

Every son was a chapter in a catechism I did not know I was being taught. I will not finish it. I am not done being fathered, and they are not done being mine.

So I leave you where I live, which is in the middle of it, with the hand beginning to open and the table still set and the vacancy still there underneath the joy, and the Father, the real one, closer in the staying than I ever felt him in the arguments that first convinced me he was there. If you are a father afraid you do not know what you are doing, you are right, you do not, and it does not matter as much as you fear, because the thing your sons most need from you is not your competence. It is your presence, given daily, over years, in a room you may never have seen anyone stay in. Stay anyway. Carry the weight where they can see it. Repent quickly. Delight in them out loud. Wait when you have to. Keep the table. And when the time comes, open your hand. You will be a different man on the far side of it, and the difference will be them, and the Father who was fathering you the whole time you thought you were only fathering them.